

# Homelab Journal

## 📅 Homelab Journal

A running log of what I've built, broken, and learned along the way.

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### Entry 1 — July 29, 2026: Homelab Setup Begins

**Goal:** Set up my first virtual machine to start building hands-on IT/security skills.

**What I did:** - Chose **UTM** as my hypervisor after discovering that VirtualBox has weak/unreliable support on Apple Silicon Macs (M1-M4). UTM uses Apple's native virtualization framework, making it a much better fit for my hardware. - Downloaded Ubuntu Server to create my first VM.

**Issues encountered (and how I solved them):** 1. **Architecture mismatch** — My first VM creation attempt failed because I had downloaded the amd64 (Intel/x86) version of the Ubuntu ISO, but my Mac's Apple Silicon chip requires an arm64 build. Fixed by re-downloading the correct ARM64 ISO. 2. **Torrent file instead of ISO** — On a later attempt, I discovered the file I'd downloaded was actually a .iso.torrent file, not the real disk image, which is why the VM showed almost no disk usage. Solved by finding the direct ISO download link instead of the torrent option. 3. **Boot loop after installation** — After installation completed, the VM kept booting back into the installer instead of the newly installed OS. This was because UTM didn't automatically eject the installation ISO. Fixed by manually detaching the ISO from the VM's virtual CD/DVD drive in settings before rebooting.

**Result:** Successfully installed **Ubuntu 26.04 LTS** as my first working homelab VM.

**Skills practiced:** - Basic Linux CLI navigation: whoami, pwd, ls, cd, mkdir, touch - Package management: sudo apt update, sudo apt upgrade - Using sudo and authenticating with a password in the terminal - Reading and interpreting boot logs / systemd service output - General VM troubleshooting: architecture compatibility, boot media, boot order

**Next steps:** - Set up SSH access to the VM for remote practice - Add a second VM (Kali Linux) for security tooling practice - Start researching Active Directory lab setup (likely via a cloud VM, since Windows Server has limited support on Apple Silicon)

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### Entry 2 — [Date]

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